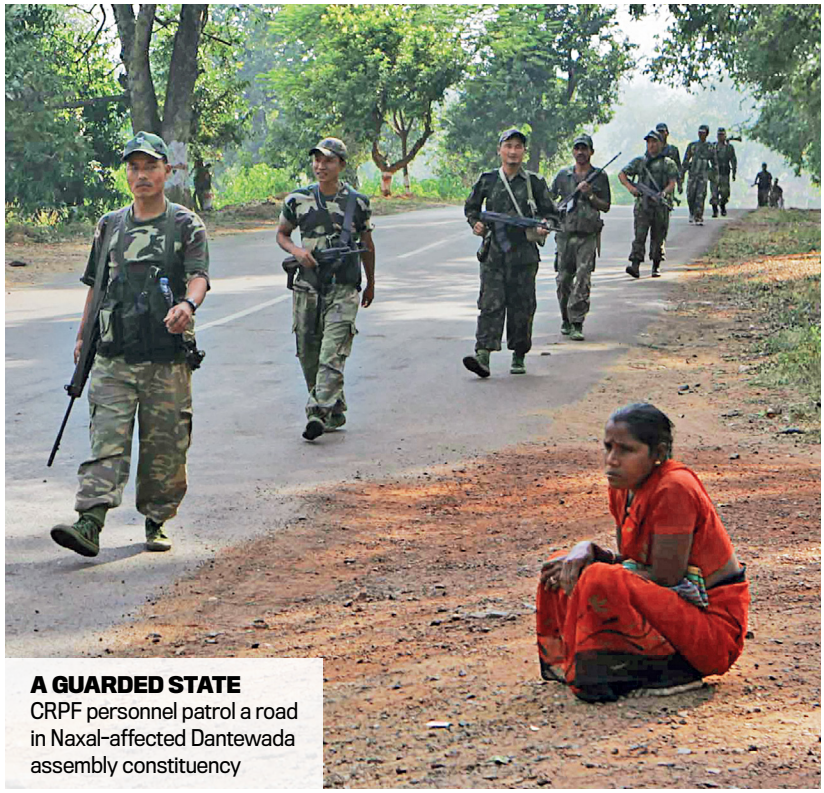
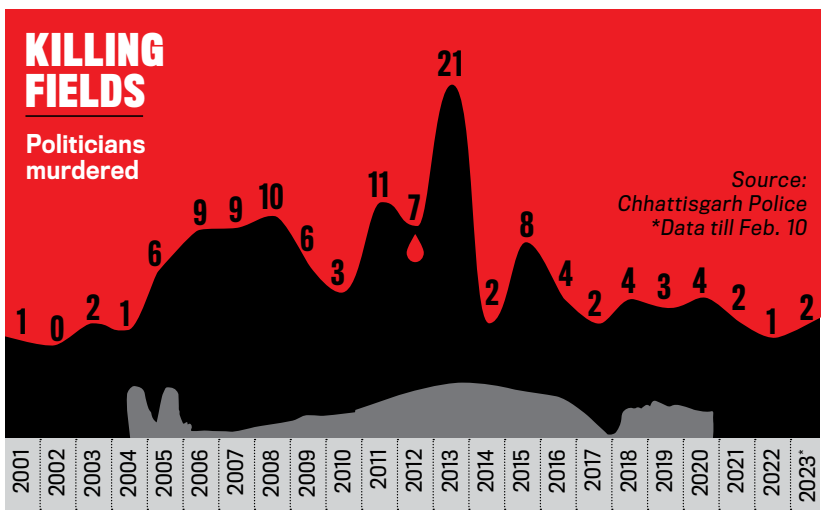
GETTY IMAGES



A GUARDED STATE
CRPF personnel patrol a road in Naxal-affected Dantewada assembly constituency



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

11, Nadda and former chief minister Raman Singh rushed to Sahu's house to meet the victim's family. A few hours after Nadda's visit, Ramdhar Alami, a BJP-aligned former sarpanch, was hacked to death at Barsoor, in Dantewada district. A note was found at the site mentioning Alami as a police informer. A week before Sahu's murder, local BJP leader Neelkanth Kakem was killed by the Maoists in Bijapur as was Budhram Kartam, a former Bastar district secretary of the party.

THE SPATE OF MAOIST KILLINGS TARGETING BJP LEADERS IN THE RUN-UP TO ELECTIONS HAS GIVEN RISE TO CONSPIRACY THEORIES

Sahu's murder was allegedly the handiwork of a small action team of Maoists that has been used in the past for carrying out assassinations within populated areas. However, no pamphlet or note was left behind—as is a regular Maoist practice after a murder. The note, which explains the 'reason' for the move, is meant to send out a message to the general population—a kind of reassurance that only those working for the security establishment are targeted. The absence of a pamphlet gave credence to conspiracy theories. "This is the third incident of murder of senior BJP workers in a month. The Congress government has failed to control the incidents. Why are only BJP workers being targeted? A political context can easily be drawn from the murders," said Raman after Sahu's murder.

Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel dismisses the conspiracy angle and says the BJP can hand over the probe in all cases to central agencies. "We were probing the 2019 murder of (BJP) MLA Bhima Mandavi, but the Centre handed over the case to the NIA (National Investigation Agency). What came of it? In these incidents too, the Centre can hand over the probe to any agency, we have no objection," says Baghel. "The police have been asked to address an all-party meet and inform leaders to follow all security protocols. We have never compromised on security. BJP leaders who are not holding any office continue to enjoy security cover even though the Centre has reduced it for the Gandhi family," adds Baghel.

Killings of politicians are not new to strife-torn Bastar. From the Jheeram Ghati massacre in May 2013 that nearly wiped out the entire Congress leadership in the state to Mandavi's murder via a landmine blast in May 2019, a total of 118 politicians of varied standing and affiliations have been killed between 2001 and 2023. The biggest number in a single year—21—was logged in the year of